Bunny Bunny

By Alan Zweibel

GILDA: **(Pg 1-2)** *(July 1975)* Can you help me be a parakeet

ALAN: Excuse me?

GILDA: I think it could be funny if I stood on a big perch and squished up my face, like this . . .

ALAN: Uh-huh . . . .

GILDA: But I need a writer to help me figure out what the parakeet should say. Could you help me?

ALAN: Sure.

GILDA: I'm Gilda *(sticks out her hand)*

ALAN: I'm Alan *(handshake)*

GILDA: I know.

ALAN: How do you know?

GILDA: I took the liberty of asking one of the other writers if he knew the name of the big, nervous-looking guy who's trying to keep a low profile by sitting in the corner behind the huge potted tree, and he said your name was Alan . . .

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Gilda Radner exploded on television and into American homes every Saturday night, stealing the hearts of millions with her host of brilliantly eccentric characters, now indelibly etched into modern memory,*

ACTRESS: *(assuming each character's qualities as they are introduced) like Lisa Loopner (nerdy snort), Emily Litella, ("Nevermind") and the ornery Italian news commentator Roseanne Roseannadanna, (It's always something!")*

ACTOR: *That final something for Gilda began in 1986 when she started experiencing fatigue and sharp pains in her upper thighs. 10 months later, she was given the diagnosis – Stage IV ovarian cancer.*

ACTRESS: *Alan Zweibel, one of the first writers for Saturday Night Live, and Gilda Radner shared a 15-year friendship. A friendship that survived marriages to other people, career changes and cancer.*

ACTOR: *In this selection, he pays tribute to his best friend who died on his birthday, May 20, 1989, at the age of 42.*

TOGETHER: *Bunny Bunny*

FOR REVIEW

ALAN: (Pg 105 – 107) *(Gilda looks very sad)* Hey . . . what's the matter?

GILDA: I'm becoming a cliché. One of those show business cliché's who's popular with strangers but has no personal life

ALAN: But you were real happy when I spoke to you from Europe.

GILDA: I know.

ALAN: You're not with that guy anymore? *(shakes her head)* What happened?

GILDA: He didn't take me seriously. Look, it's probably just as much my fault as his. People tell me that I confuse guys, and maybe I do. They see me one way, but then they get to know me and they're disappointed. I have enough trouble being strong for myself, let alone for someone who gets paranoid when I'm quiet or gets threated when I say "Bunny Bunny."

ALAN: What's that?

GILDA: Oh, nothing really . . . it's silly.

ALAN: Tell me.

GILDA: When I was a little girl, I used to be afraid of the dark. We lived in this big house and at night, there'd be these scary shadows on my bedroom walls. So, what I'd do, was get under the covers and say the words "Bunny Bunny" to protect me from the shadows while I was sleeping.

ALAN: Why "Bunny Bunny?"

GILDA: I really don't remember. Except that it worked. When I started getting older, I cut back and only had to say it once a week, and finally, once a month – just to be on the safe side. On the first day of every month, the first words I say when I wake up are "Bunny Bunny" to make sure it's going to be a good month and keep me safe from anything bad that could happen.

ALAN: I understand. It's not silly. You were a kid, and you . . .

GILDA: I still say it. Does that sound stupid?

ALAN: No.

GILDA: But I'm in my thirties.

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ALAN: So?

GILDA: And it still doesn't sound stupid?

ALAN: No, not at all.

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GILDA: **(Pg 76-77)** Could you do me a favor, Zweibel?

ALAN: Sure

GILDA: Promise you won't get upset? Or hurt . . . because I mean this in a good way.

ALAN: What, Gilda?

GILDA: Could you please not call me Gilda anymore?

ALAN: Excuse me?

GILDA: I mean it.

ALAN: Why don't you want me to call you Gilda anymore?

GILDA: Because everyone does.

ALAN: Well, isn't that your name?

GILDA: I'm scared, Zweibel. I'm real excited about *Saturday Night Live.* It's what I've always wanted and it's fun, but I don't trust it. It's a weird feeling having strangers call me by my name and knowing all sorts of things about my life that I never told them. *(mimics fans)* **(Pg 71)** "Hey, Gilda, you're really funny." "Hey Gilda, my birthday's also in June." "Hey Gilda, I also used to be real fat."

(Pg 77) So it would make me feel better if ***you*** didn't call me what everyone else did.

ALAN: . . . Sure.

GILDA: Thanks.

ALAN: Any thoughts about what I should call you?

GILDA: . . . Gilbert.

ALAN: Gilbert?

GILDA: Yeah. Gilbert

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GILDA: **(Pg 165-166)** *(on the phone)* Hello?

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ALAN: Robin said that we should talk. . .

GILDA: *(interrupts)* Hi, Zweibel.

ALAN: She said you weren't feeling well.

GILDA: And she told me you didn't believe it.

ALAN: Look, all I know is that I was out there in Los Angeles for two months doing that pilot, and we didn't see each other, not even once.

GILDA: I know.

ALAN: We made all these lunch plans and dinner plans and we were even supposed to go to that movie premier and I'm supposed to be the one who's the flake, but you're the one who broke these dates off every single time.

GILDA: Look, Zweibel, the truth is, I haven't been feeling well . . .

ALAN: For two months? What's wrong with you?

GILDA: I have no strength. And I'm tired all of the time. I swear to you, Zweibel, every time you and I made plans I really wanted to see you, but then I ended up going to bed early or going to some doctor and that's what my whole life has been lately.

ALAN: And what do the doctors say?

GILDA: That I have Epstein-Bar virus. It's horrible. My mind wants to do everything I always do, but my body is just too tired to do it.

ALAN: Look, honey, I'm sorry if I misread the situation.

GILDA: You wouldn't be you if you didn't.

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GILDA: **(Pg 168-169)** *(on the phone)* Hi, Zweibel

ALAN: Gilbert! What a great surprise! How did you get this number?

GILDA: I called *wife* in New York and she gave it to me. How long are you out here for?

ALAN: Well, the network ordered six episodes of the show. And I'll be flying back East to be with Robin and the kids on the weekends, *but* there'll still be plenty of time for you and me to get together, whenever you feel up to it.

GILDA: Good

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ALAN: No pressure, and I promise I won't get mad even if you have to break . . .

GILDA: No, I really want to see you.

ALAN: Great, so you're feeling better?

GILDA: Zweibel?

ALAN: Yeah?

GILDA: I just found out I don't have Epstein-Barr virus.

ALAN: Hey, that's great!

GILDA: I have cancer.

ALAN: . . . Gilda?

GILDA: I have ovarian cancer, Zweibel, and I need you to help me get through this part of my life.

ALAN: I will.

GILDA: You promise?

ALAN: I promise. What should I do first?

GILDA: Make me laugh.

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ALAN: **(Pg 189)** *(June 1, 1989)* About 14 years ago, I was hiding behind a potted plant and this girl asked if I could help her be a parakeet, and I've been smitten with Gilda ever since. And now? Well, I haven't mourned, and I haven't even cried yet, because even though she's dead, I just don't want her to die. I don't know why God makes people and then takes them back. Just like I don't know if I'm supposed to celebrate the fact that Gilda was in my life or feel cheated that she's not here anymore. But even though her body grew to betray her, spirits just don't die. And that's what Gilda was. Even as an adult, she was still a little girl who believed in fairy tales, and that if she said "Bunny Bunny" on the first of every month, it would bring her love, laughter and peace. Well Gilda, today is June 1st, and if you're in a place where you can't say it, I'll say it for you.

TOGETHER: Bunny Bunny

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2002 National Qualifier
2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2024 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier
CA State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

FOR INTRO:

Sample video of Gilda Radner as Lisa Loopner:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MYQTyOA38YA

Sample video of Gilda Radner as Emily Litella:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fZLeaSWY37I

Sample video of Gilda Radner as Roseanne Roseannadanna:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=k59d-xMvooA

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